THE ATHOS GROUP

The Nine Rules of Vision-Based Fundraising

Inspiring people to invest in a compelling vision of a better future, and in a credible strategy and team capable of realizing it.

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1 Fund the future, not the organization.

Never lead with what your organization needs. Lead with what the world needs. Institutions exist to accomplish something beyond themselves. The organization is the vehicle. The vision is the destination.

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2 Make the invisible visible.

The fundraiser's task is to help others see the vision. If they can see it, they can believe it. Too many visions remain abstractions. A real vision has people, places, and consequences. Describe the future with such clarity and potency that the donor is excited to live in it.

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3 Find the dream inside the donor.

The big mistake in fundraising is asking what someone might fund. Instead, discover what they care about. What do they hope for? What troubles them? What are they grateful for? What do they want their legacy to be? The deepest gifts occur when your vision meets their aspirations.

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4 Turn "you" and "me" into "we."

Never reduce a donor to a checkbook. Ask for their judgment, experience, and relationships. Share problems with them, not just successes. Give them something to think about. When they become intellectually and emotionally invested, they stop saying "you" and start saying "we."

5 Let the vision determine the ask.

We often decide what amount seems reasonable and then construct an ask around it. Reverse the order. First establish what ought to happen and what it will take to make it happen. Then ask what role the donor might play in bringing it about. A great gift should have consequence.

6 Surround yourself with extraordinary people.

People give to people. A vision on paper is a hypothesis. The people around it are the evidence. Before donors decide whether your future is worth funding, they decide whether you are the people who can build it. They answer that question by looking at who else has already said yes.

7 Community compounds.

Building relationships one at a time is linear: 1, 2, 3. Building a community is exponential: 1, 2, 4. Donors who feel like partners bring other donors with them. They renew, grow, and recruit. This is the entire argument for gatherings and events as fundraising infrastructure.

8 Money should follow the vision, never the reverse.

Philanthropy is partnership, not ownership. A donor's wisdom, network, and generosity can transform an institution. Listen and adapt intelligently. But never allow resources to pull you away from the vision that deserved support in the first place.

9 The gift is the beginning, not the end.

The moment someone makes a major gift, they place their hopes in your hands. Honor that. Bring them into the story of what happens next. Tell them what worked, what surprised you, and what failed, and what you learned from it. Let them meet the people whose lives they have touched. Show them what their generosity has made possible, the vision made real.

The highest form of fundraising is not receiving a gift. It is building a community of people who have decided that a particular future is worth creating together.